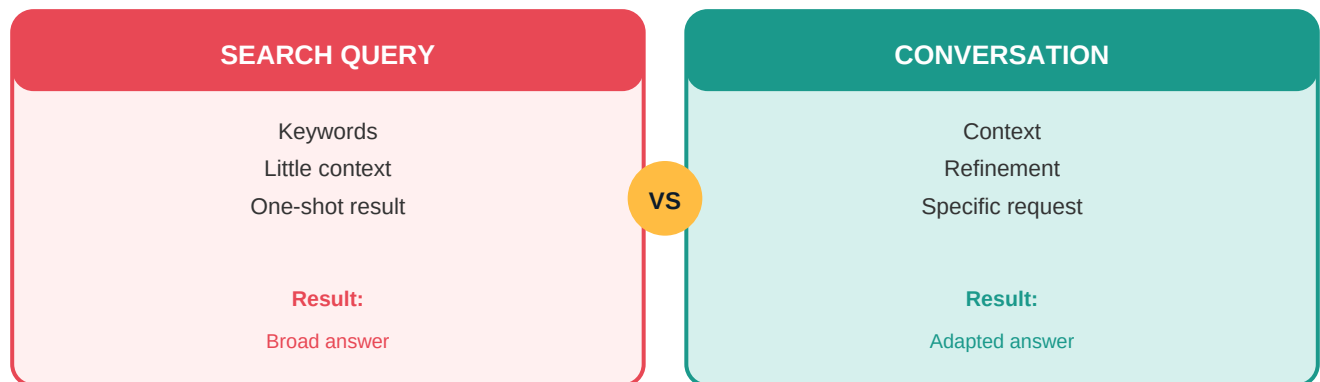


CHAPTER 4

How to Talk to an AI (It's Not Google)



THE SEARCH ENGINE HABIT Most people's first instinct when using AI is to type a search query. Short. Keyword-heavy. Punchy.

"best email subject lines"

"how to negotiate salary"

"presentation tips"

This works for Google because Google is retrieving existing documents that match your keywords. The shorter and cleaner the query, the more precisely it matches what's out there.

AI tools are not search engines. They are not retrieving existing content. They are generating new content based on what you've given them. The search-engine reflex is the single most common reason people get worse results than they could.

WHAT AI ACTUALLY DOES Without requiring a technical explanation: an AI language model generates text by working out what words are most likely to follow what came before, based on patterns learned from enormous quantities of text. It is not looking up answers. It is constructing them.

This has three practical implications:

1. MORE RELEVANT INPUT, MORE RELEVANT OUTPUT. A longer, more specific prompt does not confuse AI. It constrains the range of possible responses toward what you actually need. Specificity is an advantage.

- A FRESH CONVERSATION SHOULD NOT BE ASSUMED TO KNOW YOUR
- PREVIOUS WORK.

- Unless the platform explicitly provides and uses a memory,
- project, history, or connected-source feature, a new conversation
- begins without dependable knowledge of who you are, what
- you've discussed before, or what your preferences are. This is
- why context must be provided explicitly, and why workspaces
- (Part III) matter so much for regular users.
- AI GENERATES PLAUSIBLE TEXT, NOT NECESSARILY ACCURATE TEXT.
- AI's training teaches it what good writing looks like in a given
- context. This means it can generate fluent, confident text on
- subjects it is wrong about. The confidence in the prose is not
- correlated with the accuracy of the content. This is the most
- important habit to build: treating AI output as a draft that
- requires verification, not a source that can be trusted.

WHY IT WORKS UNDERSTANDING THE GENERATION MODEL, RATHER THAN THINKING OF AI AS AN ORACLE OR A SEARCH ENGINE

THE CONVERSATION, NOT THE QUERY AI tools work best as conversations, not as single-query exchanges. The first response is rarely the last one.

This is not because AI needs multiple chances to get things right (though sometimes it does). It is because a conversation allows you to:



PART I - A DIFFERENT WAY TO THINK ABOUT AI

Add context you forgot in the first prompt Adjust the output format based on what you see Request a deeper dive on one section Push back on something that seems wrong Ask AI to regenerate with a different constraint

Think of it as briefing a capable but uninformed colleague. The first briefing gets you a first draft. The subsequent conversation refines it. This is normal, efficient, and often faster than trying to write the perfect prompt in one go.

THE ANATOMY OF AN EFFECTIVE PROMPT Not every prompt needs all of these elements. But a complete prompt for a significant task includes:

ROLE (optional but often useful): Act as a [role] with expertise in [domain].

CONTEXT: Background information AI needs to know. Who is involved, what the situation is, what constraints apply.

TASK: Exactly what you want AI to do. Use a clear action verb. Be specific.

SOURCE MATERIAL (when relevant): [Attached document / pasted text / data]

OUTPUT REQUIREMENTS: Format, length, tone, audience, structure.

VERIFICATION REQUEST (for factual or high-stakes output): Please flag any claims you are uncertain about, any assumptions you've made, and any information I should verify independently.

This is not a template to apply rigidly. It is a map of what a complete prompt includes. For quick tasks, you might cover all of this in two sentences. For complex tasks, each element might be

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a paragraph.

TRY THIS TAKE A STANDARD QUERY YOU MIGHT TYPE INTO A SEARCH ENGINE AND REWRITE IT AS AN AI PROMPT USING TH

For example:

Search query: "how to negotiate salary"

AI prompt: "I am about to have a salary negotiation conversation with my manager. I have been in this role for two years, my performance reviews have both been 'exceeds expectations', and I know from a conversation with a colleague that my salary is about 12% below the market rate for this role in London. I am asking for a 15% increase. Help me prepare for this conversation: what arguments are strongest, what objections might I face, and how should I handle the moment when they counter with a lower number? Tone: calm and factual, not aggressive."

Notice the difference in what AI has to work with.

ASKING AI TO THINK, NOT JUST WRITE One of the most underused techniques is asking AI to reason through a problem before producing an answer.

When AI generates text quickly, it sometimes takes the most obvious route. Asking AI to think first, to break down the problem, identify considerations, or outline before drafting, tends to produce more thoughtful, more accurate results.

Phrases that invoke this:

"Before answering, think through the main considerations."



PART I - A DIFFERENT WAY TO THINK ABOUT AI

"First give me an outline, then draft the full document." "Walk me through your reasoning." "What are the main risks or failure points here?"

This works because it changes the pattern of text generation, the model is working through intermediate steps rather than jumping to a conclusion. You can think of it as asking someone to show their work rather than just hand you an answer.

PRO TIP WHEN YOU RECEIVE AN OUTPUT THAT IS CLOSE TO WHAT YOU WANT BUT NOT QUITE RIGHT, DO NOT START AGAIN

"That's good but the tone is too formal, can you make it sound more conversational?" or "The summary is accurate but too long, cut it to three bullet points and keep only the most important point in each." Iteration on an existing draft is almost always faster than rewriting.

WATCH OUT AI CONFIDENTLY PRODUCES WRONG ANSWERS. THE FLUENCY OF AI PROSE, THE FACT THAT IT READS WELL, S

polished prose is not evidence of accuracy.

WHAT PART I HAS ESTABLISHED You now have the foundation:

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Generic inputs produce generic outputs because AI fills gaps with averages The AI Interaction Stack identifies the eleven layers that determine output quality The 7 Questions give you a portable framework for activating the right layers A basic AI chat is a generation tool, not a retrieval tool; search and connected-source tools change what it can access, and conversation is the natural mode of interaction

Part II takes each element of a strong interaction and develops it into a skill.



PART I - A DIFFERENT WAY TO THINK ABOUT AI

PART II Build Better Interactions

The five chapters in Part II develop the core skills that apply to every AI interaction you will ever have. Each chapter takes one element of the AI Interaction Stack and teaches you to use it deliberately. Together they account for the majority of the quality difference between people who get good results from AI and people who don't.



IN THIS PART

CHAPTER 5 CHAPTER 6 Give AI a Job, Not Just a Question Context Is Everything

CHAPTER 7 CHAPTER 8 Instructions That Actually Work Examples Change Everything

CHAPTER 9 Control the Output